Endangered Species

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Conservation for Endangered Species

Endangered Species

- An endangered species is at risk of becoming **extinct**
- There are several reasons why a species can become endangered - the **population of the species may fall below a critical level** due to
  - **hunting**
  - **climate change**
  - **pollution**
  - **loss of habitat**
  - **introduction of non-native species** that outcompete native species
- Endangered species can be helped by **conservation measures** such as:
  - **education** programmes
  - **captive breeding** programmes
  - **monitoring and legal protection** of the species and of their habitats
  - **seed banks** as a conservation measure for plants - seeds of endangered plant species are carefully stored so that new plants may be grown in the future
- A species may be at risk of becoming extinct **if there is not enough genetic variation in the population** as random changes in the environment may quickly cause extinction because the **remaining organisms are all very similar and may not have the adaptations to survive such changes**
- There are moral, cultural and scientific reasons for conservation programmes, including:
  - **reducing extinction rates** of both plant and animal species
  - keeping damage to food chains and food webs to a minimum and **protecting vulnerable ecosystems** (eg the rainforests)
  - **protecting our future food supply** and **maintaining nutrient cycles and possible sources of future medical drugs and fuels**

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